BOOKS

PRISON DIARY

From Phansi Yard recounts **Sudha Bharadwaj**'s time at Yerawada Jail and paints a poignant portrait of her fellow inmates

A new addition to India's long tradition of prison lit (soon to get longer, probably), *From Phansi Yard*, Sudha Bharadwaj's compassionate, highly readable memoir of her time in Yerawada Jail, shines light on the daily realities of women prisoners.

In a Q&A introduction, Bharadwaj talks of the circumstances of her arrest and her life in this "cage with a view". She also explains the gaps in her accounts, since she is not allowed to discuss the details of the case against her. But most of her book is about her fellow prisoners in Phansi Yard. The word *phansi* means "hanging". She wrote about the women here, she says, because she had the time to do it. In her later stint in Byculla Women's Jail, she was occupied in providing legal help to her fellow prisoners.

These individual portraits also contain gaps. An outline is rapidly sketched but, as in the writer's own story, legal details must not be filled in, and no woman is identified by name. From Bharadwaj's introduction, we know that she had long lived among rural working women, eating and dressing like them. That means she doesn't give the extra detail we might find in a narrative with a more urban, explanatory tone. But that only deepens the authenticity of her portraits and, with all these elisions, a distinct, vivid personality is often created.

Bharadwaj recreates the chores, cliques, caste tensions, overcrowding, court outings and money transactions that shape their lives. She tells the good with the bad. The food, for example, is rather good, because the prisoners of Yerawada grow vegetables and women do all the cooking. The healthcare is better than what many of the women and their children would get at home. A Women's Day celebration with song and dance (and omitting any mention of feminism or the patriarchy) shows us the atmosphere could at times brighten, even with baton-armed women constables lined up behind the chairs. And she records "little gestures of love", as from a parolee who phones a fellow prisoner's family and reports back to tell her they are well.

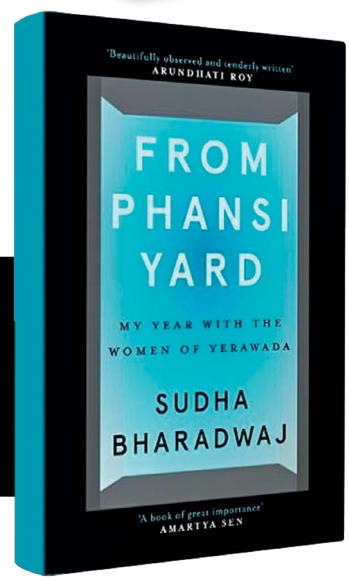
BHARADWAJ recreates the chores, cliques, caste tensions, overcrowding, court outings and money transactions that shape the lives of prisoners

Not that the writer sugarcoats the facts. Though there are "judicial hostages" in Phansi Yard, held until their absconding guilty men can be found, most women are, in fact, accused or convicted of serious crimes. By law, they must be informed of the status of their cases, appeals and parole. But other than the richer women who are in for embezzlement, most don't know how long they will be there, or whether there is any chance of appeal or reprieve. They live in a fog of ignorance.

In 2020, Bharadwaj left Yerawada to be held in Byculla for nearly another two years. During that time, she actively wrote applications for prisoners, and acknowledges that she had a "spectacular" failure rate. Ultimately, the inadequacy of legal representation and denial of the right to a speedy trial are the worst deprivations suffered by prisoners in India.

Sudha Bharadwaj was granted bail in December 2021. She is still not a free woman. ■

–Latha Anantharaman



FROM PHANSI YARD: My Year with the Women of Yerawada
by Sudha Bharadwaj
JUGGERNAUT
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